

Payap University
The International College

IEC 493: Selected Topics
Department of English Communication Arts

**Digital Distraction in the Classroom: Its Impact on Class Participation Among
International College Students at Payap University**

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Abstract

Digital technology has become an essential component of higher education, providing students with convenient access to learning materials, communication platforms, and academic resources. Although smartphones, laptops, and tablets can enhance learning experiences, they may also distract students from classroom activities when used for non-academic purposes. This study investigates how digital distraction influences class participation among students at the International College of Payap University. A mixed-methods research design was employed, combining quantitative data from questionnaires with qualitative data obtained through semi-structured interviews. Ten students representing five academic programs completed the survey, while five students participated in individual interviews to share their experiences with technology use during class. The findings indicate that most students frequently use digital devices during lectures and acknowledge that off-task activities, such as checking social media or responding to messages, reduce their concentration and willingness to participate in classroom discussions. However, participants also recognized that digital devices can support learning when used responsibly for academic purposes, including note-taking, accessing course materials, using translation applications, and searching for additional information. The study concludes that digital technology should not be completely prohibited in university classrooms. Instead, instructors should establish clear guidelines that encourage responsible device use while minimizing digital distraction. These findings provide practical recommendations for creating balanced technology-supported learning environments that promote active participation and student engagement.

Keywords: digital distraction, classroom participation, mobile technology, student engagement, higher education, International College, Payap University

1. Introduction

1.1 Background of the Study

Digital technology has transformed the way students learn in higher education. Smartphones, laptops, tablets, and online learning platforms have become common tools that support communication, research, collaboration, and access to educational resources. These technologies allow students to search for information instantly, participate in virtual discussions, complete assignments electronically, and communicate with instructors more efficiently. As technology continues to develop, universities increasingly integrate digital devices into classroom teaching to create more flexible and interactive learning environments.

Despite these educational advantages, digital technology also presents new challenges for both students and instructors. One of the most common concerns is **digital distraction**, which occurs when students use technological devices for activities unrelated to learning during class. Instead of paying attention to lectures or participating in discussions, students may browse social media, respond to text messages, watch videos, or play games. These off-task behaviors divide students' attention, interrupt the learning process, and reduce meaningful classroom interaction.

Digital distraction has become a growing concern in higher education because classroom participation plays an important role in students' academic development. Active participation encourages students to communicate their ideas, ask questions, solve problems collaboratively, and develop critical thinking skills. When students become distracted by their digital devices, they may lose concentration, miss important information, or hesitate to contribute to classroom discussions. As a result, excessive technology use can negatively influence both individual learning outcomes and the overall classroom atmosphere.

This issue is particularly relevant in multicultural learning environments such as the International College at Payap University. Students come from diverse cultural, linguistic, and educational backgrounds, making classroom communication an essential component of learning. Many courses, including English Communication Arts, International Business Management, Hospitality Industry Management, English for Career Development, and Information Technology, emphasize discussion, presentations, teamwork, and collaborative learning. Active

participation is therefore necessary for students to develop academic knowledge as well as communication and interpersonal skills.

At the same time, international students often depend on digital technology for legitimate academic purposes. Translation applications, online dictionaries, learning management systems, artificial intelligence tools, and electronic course materials help students overcome language barriers and improve their understanding of course content. Consequently, digital devices serve two different roles in the classroom: they can enhance learning when used appropriately, but they can also become significant sources of distraction when used for personal entertainment or social communication.

Because of this dual role, educators face an important challenge. Completely banning digital devices may limit students' access to valuable learning resources, while unrestricted use may encourage behaviors that reduce concentration and participation. Finding an appropriate balance between educational technology and classroom engagement has therefore become an important issue for higher education institutions.

Although many previous studies have examined digital distraction in university classrooms, relatively little research has focused on international students studying in multicultural educational settings in Thailand. The learning experiences of students at Payap University's International College may differ from those reported in other countries because of language diversity, cultural differences, and the frequent use of digital tools to support communication and learning. Understanding how these students perceive digital distraction is essential for developing effective teaching strategies that encourage active participation while maintaining the educational benefits of technology.

Therefore, this study investigates the impact of digital distraction on classroom participation among International College students at Payap University. It explores students' patterns of digital device use, identifies the major sources of distraction, examines how technology influences classroom engagement, and investigates the strategies students and instructors use to reduce digital distraction. The findings are expected to provide useful recommendations for creating classroom environments that promote responsible technology use, improve student participation, and enhance the overall quality of teaching and learning.

1.2 Purpose of the Study

This study aims to investigate the impact of digital distraction on classroom participation among students at the International College, Payap University. Specifically, the study seeks to examine how students use digital devices during class, identify the major factors contributing to digital distraction, and explore how these behaviors influence classroom engagement and participation. In addition, the study investigates the strategies students and instructors use to manage digital distraction while maintaining the educational benefits of technology in university classrooms.

1.3 Research Questions

This study is guided by the following research questions:

1. How do International College students use digital devices during classroom learning?
2. What are the major sources of digital distraction among International College students?
3. How does digital distraction influence students' classroom participation and engagement?
4. What strategies do students and instructors use to reduce digital distraction while supporting effective learning?

1.4 Significance of the Study

This study contributes to a better understanding of digital distraction within a multicultural university environment. The findings may benefit students by helping them recognize how their technology-use habits influence classroom participation and academic engagement. Increased awareness may encourage students to develop more responsible digital learning behaviors and improve their ability to manage distractions during class.

The findings may also benefit instructors by providing practical insights into students' experiences with digital technology. Understanding the factors that influence classroom distraction can help lecturers design more interactive lessons, establish appropriate technology-use guidelines, and integrate digital tools into teaching more effectively.

Furthermore, this study may assist administrators at Payap University's International College in developing classroom policies that balance the educational advantages of digital technology with

the need to maintain active student participation. Rather than promoting complete restrictions, the findings support the development of responsible technology-use practices that encourage both academic engagement and digital literacy.

Finally, this research contributes to the growing body of literature on digital distraction in higher education. Since relatively few studies have focused on international students studying in multicultural classrooms in Thailand, this research provides context-specific evidence that may support future studies in similar educational settings.

2. Literature Review

2.1 Digital Technology in Higher Education

Digital technology has become an integral part of higher education, transforming the way students learn, communicate, and access academic resources. Smartphones, laptops, tablets, and other digital devices enable students to participate in online discussions, search for information instantly, complete assignments, and collaborate with classmates more efficiently. These technologies have created more flexible learning environments by allowing students to access educational materials anytime and anywhere. As universities continue integrating technology into teaching and learning, digital devices are increasingly viewed as essential tools that support academic success rather than optional learning resources.

The rapid advancement of educational technology has also encouraged instructors to incorporate digital platforms into classroom activities. Learning management systems, online quizzes, digital presentations, and collaborative applications have become common instructional tools in many universities. When integrated effectively, technology promotes active learning, increases student engagement, and encourages independent learning. Students can use digital resources to clarify difficult concepts, review lecture materials, and communicate with instructors outside the classroom. These advantages demonstrate that technology has the potential to enrich higher education by creating more interactive and accessible learning experiences (Al Fakh et al., 2020).

However, the increasing availability of digital devices also presents new challenges. Because students have constant access to entertainment applications, social media, and instant messaging services, maintaining attention during lectures has become more difficult. As a result, educators are increasingly concerned about how digital technology influences students' learning behaviors and classroom participation.

2.2 Digital Distraction in the Classroom

Digital distraction refers to the interruption of learning caused by using digital devices for activities unrelated to classroom instruction. Common examples include checking social media, replying to messages, watching videos, browsing websites, or playing games during lectures. Although these activities may appear harmless, they divide students' attention between academic and non-academic tasks, making it more difficult to process information effectively.

Research has consistently shown that multitasking during class reduces students' ability to concentrate and understand course content. Zhang (2012) explained that switching repeatedly between classroom instruction and mobile phone activities places additional demands on students' cognitive resources. Instead of focusing entirely on learning, students continuously divide their attention, which decreases comprehension, memory retention, and overall academic performance. Frequent interruptions also reduce students' ability to participate actively in classroom discussions because they may miss important explanations or lose track of ongoing conversations.

Another common form of digital distraction is excessive mobile phone use during lectures. Zhao (2021) described this behavior as the "**head-down phenomenon**," in which students spend much of the class looking at their phones rather than interacting with instructors or classmates. This behavior limits eye contact, reduces classroom communication, and weakens collaborative learning. Students become passive observers rather than active participants, creating a classroom environment with less discussion and interaction.

These findings suggest that digital distraction affects more than individual concentration. It also influences the overall learning atmosphere by reducing communication, collaboration, and student engagement.

2.3 Digital Distraction and Classroom Participation

Classroom participation is widely recognized as an important indicator of student engagement in higher education. Active participation allows students to express ideas, ask questions, respond to instructors, and collaborate with classmates. Through these interactions, students develop communication skills, strengthen critical thinking, and deepen their understanding of course content.

However, digital distraction often interferes with these learning processes. Students who frequently use their phones during lectures are generally less likely to contribute to classroom discussions or respond to instructors' questions. Instead of listening carefully, they may become occupied with notifications or online activities, reducing both their confidence and willingness to participate.

Lepp et al. (2020) found a negative relationship between mobile phone use during class and students' academic performance. Their study showed that students who regularly texted, browsed social media, or engaged in other non-academic activities during lectures tended to report lower levels of classroom engagement and achieved lower academic results. The researchers argued that digital distraction affects not only immediate participation but also students' long-term academic development because reduced classroom engagement limits opportunities for meaningful learning.

Similarly, Zhao (2021) emphasized that excessive smartphone use weakens communication between students and instructors. When students become absorbed in their devices, classroom discussions become less interactive, and collaborative learning opportunities decrease. Consequently, digital distraction influences both individual learning outcomes and the quality of classroom interaction.

2.4 Educational Benefits of Digital Technology

Although many studies highlight the negative effects of digital distraction, researchers also acknowledge that digital devices can significantly enhance learning when they are used appropriately. Mobile phones and laptops provide students with immediate access to online

libraries, academic databases, electronic dictionaries, translation applications, and artificial intelligence tools that support learning.

Al Fakih et al. (2020) found that students generally hold positive attitudes toward mobile phone use when digital devices are incorporated into structured classroom activities. For example, students benefit from using smartphones to search for academic information, complete online quizzes, access course materials, and participate in collaborative learning exercises. These activities increase students' motivation and encourage greater engagement with course content.

For international students, digital technology provides additional support by helping them overcome language barriers. Translation applications, pronunciation tools, and online reference materials allow students to understand lectures more effectively and participate more confidently in classroom discussions. Therefore, digital devices should not be viewed solely as sources of distraction but also as valuable educational resources when used responsibly.

These results suggest that the educational value of digital technology depends largely on how it is used. Purposeful academic use can enhance learning, whereas uncontrolled personal use may reduce students' attention and participation.

2.5 Strategies for Managing Digital Distraction

Because digital technology offers both benefits and challenges, researchers have proposed various strategies for reducing digital distraction while preserving the educational advantages of technology.

One approach involves limiting students' access to mobile phones during class. Sungu et al. (2025) found that removing phones from classrooms significantly improved students' academic performance, particularly among first-year university students. Their findings suggest that reducing opportunities for digital distraction allows students to concentrate more fully on classroom activities and participate more actively in learning.

However, completely banning digital devices may not always be appropriate, particularly in international classrooms where students rely on smartphones for translation, note-taking, and

accessing learning materials. Instead, many researchers recommend responsible technology integration rather than complete prohibition.

Al Fakh et al. (2020) suggested that instructors should establish clear guidelines for digital device use and design classroom activities that require students to use technology for academic purposes. Interactive learning activities, online polling systems, digital quizzes, and collaborative research tasks can help redirect students' attention toward meaningful educational experiences. At the same time, instructors can encourage students to develop self-regulation strategies, such as disabling notifications, activating focus mode, or placing phones out of sight during lectures.

These approaches recognize that digital technology is now an unavoidable part of university education. Rather than eliminating technology from the classroom, educators should help students use digital devices responsibly while minimizing opportunities for distraction.

2.6 Research Gap

Previous studies have demonstrated that digital distraction negatively influences students' concentration, classroom participation, and academic performance (Lepp et al., 2020; Zhang, 2012; Zhao, 2021). Other researchers have emphasized that digital devices can also improve learning when they are integrated into structured educational activities and supported by appropriate teaching strategies (Al Fakh et al., 2020). Furthermore, institutional approaches such as limiting mobile phone use have been shown to reduce distraction and improve academic outcomes (Sungu et al., 2025).

Despite these valuable findings, relatively little research has examined digital distraction within multicultural university classrooms where students come from diverse linguistic and cultural backgrounds. International students often depend on digital tools for translation, communication, and academic support, making their experiences different from those of students in more homogeneous educational settings. Consequently, existing research does not fully explain how digital distraction affects classroom participation in international learning environments.

This study addresses this gap by investigating the experiences of students at the International College of Payap University. Specifically, it examines students' patterns of digital device use,

identifies common sources of distraction, explores how digital distraction influences classroom participation, and investigates strategies that promote responsible technology use while maintaining active engagement in learning. By focusing on an international university context, this study contributes to a deeper understanding of how higher education institutions can balance the educational benefits of technology with the need to maintain students' attention and participation in the classroom.

3. Methodology

3.1 Research Design

This study employed a **mixed-methods research design** to examine the impact of digital distraction on classroom participation among students at the International College, Payap University. A mixed-methods approach was selected because it combines the strengths of both quantitative and qualitative research, allowing the researchers to gain a more comprehensive understanding of students' experiences with digital technology in the classroom.

The quantitative component focused on identifying general patterns of digital device use, students' perceptions of digital distraction, and its influence on classroom participation. Data were collected through a structured questionnaire distributed to International College students. The qualitative component complemented the survey findings by exploring students' personal experiences and opinions through semi-structured interviews. Combining these two methods allowed the researchers to compare statistical trends with detailed personal perspectives, thereby increasing the credibility and depth of the findings.

3.2 Participants

The participants in this study were students from the **International College, Payap University**, representing five academic programs: **English Communication Arts (EC)**, **International Business Management (IBM)**, **Hospitality Industry Management (HIM)**, **English for Career Development (ECD)**, and **Information Technology (IT)**.

A total of **ten students** participated in the questionnaire survey. To obtain more detailed information, **five students**, with one representative from each academic program, were selected for individual interviews. Participants were selected using **purposive sampling** because they had direct experience using digital devices during classroom learning and could provide meaningful insights into the research topic.

Although the sample size was relatively small, it included students from different academic disciplines, allowing the study to capture a variety of perspectives within the International College.

3.3 Research Instruments

Two research instruments were used to collect data for this study: a **questionnaire** and a **semi-structured interview**.

The questionnaire was created using **Google Forms** and consisted of multiple-choice questions, Likert-scale statements, and several open-ended questions. It was divided into four sections that examined students' frequency of digital device use during class, common sources of distraction, perceptions of how technology influences classroom participation, and strategies used to reduce digital distraction. The questionnaire provided quantitative data that could be summarized using descriptive statistics.

To obtain richer and more detailed information, semi-structured interviews were conducted with five participants. The interview questions encouraged students to describe how they normally used smartphones or laptops during class, explain situations in which digital devices distracted them, discuss the impact of technology on their classroom participation, and share strategies they used to remain focused during lectures. This interview format allowed participants to express their experiences freely while ensuring that all major research topics were addressed.

3.4 Data Collection Procedure

Data collection was conducted over a two-week period during the first semester of the 2025 academic year. Before collecting data, participants were informed about the objectives of the research and invited to participate voluntarily.

The questionnaire was distributed online through Google Forms, allowing students to complete it at their convenience. After reviewing the survey responses, five students representing different academic programs were invited to participate in individual semi-structured interviews. Each interview lasted approximately **20 to 30 minutes** and was conducted in English in a quiet environment on campus. With participants' permission, the interviews were audio-recorded to ensure that their responses could be accurately transcribed and analyzed.

Throughout the data collection process, participants were encouraged to answer honestly based on their personal experiences. No incentives were provided for participation, and students were free to withdraw from the study at any stage without any consequences.

3.5 Data Analysis

The quantitative and qualitative data were analyzed separately before being integrated to answer the research questions.

Survey responses were analyzed using descriptive statistics, including frequencies and percentages, to identify patterns of digital device use, common sources of distraction, and students' perceptions of classroom participation. The statistical results were presented in tables and figures to make the findings easier to understand and compare.

The interview data were analyzed using thematic analysis. After transcribing each interview, the researchers carefully read the transcripts several times to identify recurring ideas and meaningful patterns. Similar responses were grouped into themes, including patterns of digital device use, negative effects of digital distraction, educational benefits of technology, peer influence, and strategies for managing distraction. These themes provided a deeper understanding of students' experiences and helped explain the quantitative findings.

Finally, the quantitative and qualitative results were compared through data triangulation. This process strengthened the credibility of the study by confirming whether similar patterns appeared across both sources of data.

3.6 Ethical Considerations

Ethical principles were carefully followed throughout this study. Before participating, all students received a clear explanation of the research objectives, procedures, and their rights as research participants. Participation was entirely voluntary, and informed consent was obtained from every participant before data collection began.

To protect participants' privacy, all responses were kept confidential and anonymous. Personal information, including participants' names and student identification numbers, was not included in the research report. Instead, interview participants were identified only by their academic programs when presenting quotations. Audio recordings and questionnaire responses were stored securely and were used solely for academic purposes.

Participants were also informed that they could refuse to answer any question or withdraw from the study at any time without penalty. By following these ethical guidelines, the researchers ensured that the study respected participants' rights while maintaining academic integrity and research credibility.

Excellent. This chapter should read like a real research paper, **not just list percentages**. I'll integrate your quantitative and qualitative findings naturally and keep your original data unchanged while improving the academic writing.

4. Results and Findings

This chapter presents the findings of the study based on data collected from questionnaires and semi-structured interviews. The quantitative findings describe students' patterns of digital device use, the factors contributing to digital distraction, and their perceptions of classroom participation. The qualitative findings provide a deeper understanding of students' experiences, opinions, and strategies for managing digital distraction. Together, these findings address the research questions and illustrate how digital technology influences classroom participation among students at the International College, Payap University.

4.1 Survey Findings

4.1.1 Frequency of Digital Device Use During Class

The survey results indicate that digital devices are widely used during classroom learning. Among the ten participants, **80% reported checking their smartphones at least once during every class session**, while the remaining students indicated that they used their devices only when necessary for academic purposes. Smartphones were the most frequently used devices because they were convenient for communication, accessing course materials, searching for information, and using translation applications.

Although students recognized the educational value of digital devices, many admitted that they also used them for non-academic purposes. The most common distractions included checking social media platforms such as **Instagram, TikTok, and LINE**, replying to personal messages, and browsing online content unrelated to the lesson. These findings suggest that while digital devices support learning, they also create frequent opportunities for students to lose concentration during class.

4.1.2 Sources of Digital Distraction

The survey identified several common sources of digital distraction experienced by students during classroom learning. As shown in the questionnaire responses, **70% of participants identified social media notifications as their primary source of distraction**, while **30% admitted spending time chatting with friends or playing mobile games during lectures**.

These findings indicate that notifications and entertainment applications compete directly with classroom instruction for students' attention. Even brief interruptions caused by incoming messages or social media updates can divert students' focus away from learning activities. Several respondents explained that they often intended to check their phones for only a few seconds but eventually spent much longer scrolling through social media or replying to messages.

The findings suggest that digital distraction is often unintentional rather than deliberate. Students recognized that personal device use interrupted their concentration, yet many found it difficult to resist checking notifications during class.

4.1.3 Impact of Digital Distraction on Classroom Participation

The survey findings demonstrate that digital distraction has a noticeable influence on classroom participation. **Sixty percent of participants agreed that using smartphones during class reduced their willingness to speak or participate in classroom discussions.** In addition, **50% reported that they had missed important instructions from their lecturers because they were distracted by their phones.**

These results indicate that excessive digital device use affects more than students' attention. It also reduces active participation, limits communication with instructors, and weakens classroom interaction. Students who became distracted were less likely to ask questions, contribute to discussions, or respond confidently during classroom activities.

Despite these negative effects, students also acknowledged the educational benefits of technology. **Eighty percent of respondents agreed that smartphones and laptops supported their learning when used appropriately,** particularly for searching academic information, checking vocabulary, accessing course materials, and taking notes. This finding suggests that students distinguish between productive academic use and non-academic digital distraction.

4.1.4 Strategies for Reducing Digital Distraction

Participants reported using several personal strategies to manage digital distraction during class. **Half of the respondents (50%) stated that taking short "technology breaks" helped them regain concentration before returning their attention to classroom activities.** Another **30% reported following reminders from instructors,** while **30% said they limited their device use to class-related activities only.**

The data suggests that students primarily rely on self-regulation rather than strict classroom rules. Instead of supporting complete restrictions on digital devices, many participants preferred flexible strategies that encouraged responsible technology use while allowing access to educational resources.

Students were also asked whether they supported classroom policies requiring mobile phones to be switched off or stored during lectures. **Sixty percent agreed with implementing such a policy, while 20% disagreed and another 20% strongly disagreed.** These responses indicate that although many students recognize the benefits of minimizing phone use during lectures,

others believe that smartphones remain valuable learning tools and should remain accessible when needed for academic purposes.

Overall, the survey results demonstrate that students recognize both the advantages and disadvantages of digital technology. While many acknowledged that smartphones sometimes reduce concentration and classroom participation, they also emphasized the importance of maintaining access to digital resources that support learning.

4.2 Interview Findings

The semi-structured interviews provided a deeper understanding of students' experiences with digital technology during classroom learning. Five students representing different academic programs shared their perspectives on digital device use, classroom participation, and strategies for reducing distraction. The interview findings were organized into five major themes.

4.2.1 Patterns of Digital Device Use

All interview participants reported using digital devices regularly during classroom learning, although their purposes varied according to their academic programs and learning needs.

A participant from the **English Communication Arts** program explained,

"I use AI tools to find ideas when I need to share something in class."

This response suggests that digital technology can encourage classroom participation when students use it to prepare ideas before contributing to discussions.

Similarly, a student from International Business Management explained that although his laptop was primarily used for presentation slides and note-taking, he still checked personal messages several times during each class.

A participant from the Hospitality Industry Management program reported using her smartphone to record notes but admitted that she occasionally opened TikTok when classroom activities became less engaging.

Meanwhile, students from English for Career Development and Information Technology described using translation applications, programming resources, and online tutorials to support their learning. These responses demonstrate that digital devices play an important educational role, particularly in courses requiring language support or technical problem-solving.

Overall, the interviews indicate that digital devices have become essential learning tools for many students. However, academic use frequently overlaps with personal use, increasing opportunities for distraction.

4.2.2 Influence of Digital Distraction on Classroom Participation

Most interview participants acknowledged that digital distraction reduced their concentration and limited their classroom participation.

One participant explained,

"Sometimes I miss the teacher's instructions and have to ask my classmates what was said."

This response demonstrates that even brief moments of distraction can interrupt students' understanding of classroom activities and reduce their confidence to participate in discussions.

Another participant commented,

"When I look at my phone, I lose my focus and sometimes forget the question the teacher asked."

Similarly, one student described becoming increasingly passive during lessons whenever she spent too much time using her smartphone.

These responses suggest that multitasking weakens students' ability to remain actively engaged throughout classroom activities. Rather than encouraging participation, unnecessary phone use often results in reduced communication and lower confidence when responding to instructors.

4.2.3 Peer Influence and Classroom Environment

All interview participants observed that digital distraction affected not only individual students but also the overall classroom atmosphere.

One participant explained,

"When many students are looking at their phones, the class becomes quiet because fewer people want to join the discussion."

Another student stated that seeing classmates using social media sometimes encouraged others to do the same, creating a chain reaction of distraction throughout the classroom.

These responses suggest that digital distraction can spread through peer influence, making it more difficult for instructors to maintain active classroom participation. As more students become occupied with their devices, classroom discussions become less interactive and collaborative.

4.2.4 Educational Benefits of Digital Technology

Although students discussed many negative effects of digital distraction, every participant also emphasized that digital devices were valuable educational tools when used appropriately.

One participant explained,

"Translation apps help me understand difficult vocabulary immediately."

Another student commented,

"For programming classes, online tutorials help me solve problems much faster."

Similarly, a participant from the English Communication Arts program stated that AI tools helped generate ideas before classroom discussions, making participation easier and more confident.

These responses demonstrate that students do not view digital technology as inherently harmful. Instead, they believe that the educational value of technology depends on how it is used during classroom learning.

4.2.5 Strategies for Managing Digital Distraction

Participants described several practical strategies they used to reduce digital distraction during class.

Common approaches included turning off notifications, activating Focus Mode, switching devices to Airplane Mode, sitting closer to the front of the classroom, and temporarily disconnecting from the internet. Several students explained that these techniques helped them concentrate while still allowing them to access digital resources when necessary.

Participants also highlighted the importance of instructor support. Walking around the classroom, reminding students to stay engaged, and incorporating interactive learning activities encouraged students to pay greater attention.

Although students supported responsible technology use, most opposed a complete ban on smartphones. As one participant explained,

"Phones should stay with us because they are useful, but we must learn how to control ourselves."

This statement summarizes the overall perspective shared by most interview participants. Rather than eliminating digital devices from classrooms, students believed that developing self-discipline and responsible technology use offered a more practical solution for improving classroom participation.

5. Discussion

This study examined how digital distraction influences classroom participation among students at the International College, Payap University. The findings indicate that digital technology has both positive and negative effects on students' learning experiences. While smartphones, laptops, and tablets provide convenient access to educational resources, they also create opportunities for distraction that reduce students' attention and classroom participation. The discussion below interprets the major findings by comparing them with previous research and considering their implications for teaching and learning in higher education.

One of the most significant findings of this study is that digital devices have become an essential part of students' daily learning. Almost all participants reported using smartphones or laptops during class for academic purposes, including searching for information, accessing course materials, using translation applications, taking notes, and preparing classroom presentations. This finding supports the study by Al Fakhri et al. (2020), who argued that digital devices can improve learning motivation and engagement when they are integrated into structured classroom activities. For international students, digital technology is particularly valuable because it provides immediate access to translation tools, pronunciation guides, online dictionaries, and artificial intelligence applications that help overcome language barriers. These resources allow students to understand lessons more effectively and participate more confidently in classroom discussions.

Despite these educational benefits, the findings also reveal that digital distraction remains a common challenge in university classrooms. Most participants admitted checking social media, replying to personal messages, or browsing non-academic content during lectures. Although these interruptions were often brief, students acknowledged that they reduced their concentration and occasionally caused them to miss important instructions from lecturers. This finding is consistent with Zhang (2012), who explained that multitasking during learning increases cognitive demands and reduces students' ability to process information effectively. When students divide their attention between classroom instruction and digital entertainment, they become less capable of following discussions, understanding explanations, and responding to questions. Consequently, even short periods of distraction may negatively affect learning outcomes.

The findings further demonstrate that digital distraction influences students' willingness to participate in classroom activities. Many participants explained that they became less likely to ask questions or contribute to discussions after becoming distracted by their smartphones. Several students also reported losing confidence because they had missed part of the lesson while checking their devices. These responses suggest that digital distraction affects not only students' attention but also their communication and engagement. This finding supports Lepp et al. (2020), who found that frequent mobile phone use during lectures is associated with lower classroom participation and weaker academic performance. Students who pay less attention during class

often miss opportunities to express their ideas, interact with instructors, and collaborate with classmates.

Another important finding concerns the influence of peers on students' digital behavior. Interview participants observed that when several students began using their phones during class, others often followed the same behavior. As more students became distracted, classroom discussions gradually became quieter, and fewer students participated in learning activities. This finding reflects the "head-down phenomenon" described by Zhao (2021), in which students focus on their mobile phones instead of maintaining eye contact and interacting with instructors or classmates. Such behavior weakens classroom communication and creates a less engaging learning environment. In multicultural classrooms like those at Payap University's International College, where communication and collaboration are essential, reduced participation may have an even greater impact on students' language development and interpersonal skills.

Although participants acknowledged the negative effects of digital distraction, they did not support completely banning smartphones from classrooms. Instead, they believed that digital devices should remain available because they are valuable learning tools when used responsibly. Many students explained that they regularly used translation applications, online references, artificial intelligence tools, and digital note-taking applications to support their studies. These findings reinforce the argument presented by Al Fakhri et al. (2020) that the educational value of technology depends on how it is integrated into teaching rather than on the technology itself. Therefore, the challenge for educators is not to eliminate digital devices but to encourage students to use them purposefully.

Interestingly, this data differs slightly from the recommendations of Sungu et al. (2025), who suggested that removing phones from classrooms could improve students' academic performance. While the participants in the present study agreed that reducing unnecessary phone use would improve concentration, they also emphasized that international students often depend on smartphones for language support and quick access to academic resources. As a result, a complete prohibition may not be practical within a multicultural educational environment. Instead, students favored balanced classroom policies that allow technology for academic purposes while discouraging non-academic activities during lectures.

The study also highlights the importance of self-regulation in reducing digital distraction. Rather than relying solely on institutional policies, many participants reported using personal strategies such as turning off notifications, activating Focus Mode, placing phones on Airplane Mode, sitting near the front of the classroom, or disconnecting from the internet during lectures. These strategies demonstrate that students recognize their responsibility for managing digital distractions. At the same time, participants appreciated instructors who reminded students to remain attentive, moved around the classroom, and designed interactive learning activities that encouraged active participation. These findings suggest that reducing digital distraction requires cooperation between students and instructors rather than depending entirely on classroom rules.

5.1 Educational Implications

The findings of this study have several practical implications for higher education. First, instructors should establish clear expectations regarding digital device use at the beginning of each course. Rather than introducing strict bans, lecturers may encourage responsible technology use by clearly explaining when digital devices should be used for learning and when they should be put away.

Second, instructors should design more interactive classroom activities that require students to use technology for meaningful academic purposes. Activities such as online quizzes, collaborative research tasks, classroom polling, and digital presentations can help redirect students' attention toward learning while reducing opportunities for off-task behavior.

Third, universities should provide students with guidance on digital self-regulation and responsible technology use. Workshops or orientation programs focusing on digital literacy, time management, and attention management may help students develop healthier learning habits and become more aware of the effects of digital distraction.

Finally, because many international students rely on digital tools to overcome language barriers, educational institutions should recognize that smartphones and laptops can support learning when used appropriately. Developing balanced classroom policies that combine educational flexibility with responsible technology use may be more effective than implementing complete restrictions on digital devices.

Overall, the results suggest that digital technology should be viewed as a valuable educational resource rather than simply as a source of distraction. The key challenge for universities is to create learning environments in which technology enhances classroom participation instead of reducing it.

6. Conclusion

Digital technology has become an essential part of higher education, offering students convenient access to learning resources, communication tools, and academic support. This study examined how digital distraction influences classroom participation among students at the International College, Payap University. The findings indicate that although smartphones, laptops, and tablets provide significant educational benefits, their inappropriate use during lectures can reduce students' concentration, classroom participation, and overall engagement.

The survey and interview findings demonstrate that many students frequently use digital devices during class for both academic and personal purposes. While educational activities such as searching for information, using translation applications, accessing online resources, and taking notes support learning, non-academic activities—including checking social media, replying to messages, and browsing entertainment content—often interrupt students' attention. These distractions reduce students' willingness to participate in classroom discussions and may cause them to miss important information presented by instructors.

At the same time, the findings reveal that students do not believe digital devices should be completely prohibited in university classrooms. Instead, they prefer balanced approaches that encourage responsible technology use while maintaining access to valuable learning resources. Participants emphasized that self-discipline, instructor guidance, and interactive teaching strategies are more effective than strict technology bans in promoting active classroom participation.

This study highlights the importance of creating learning environments that integrate digital technology in meaningful and purposeful ways. By establishing clear classroom expectations, encouraging active learning, and promoting responsible digital behavior, educators can reduce unnecessary distraction while preserving the educational benefits of technology. Such

approaches are particularly important in multicultural learning environments, where digital tools often support communication, language development, and collaborative learning.

Although this study provides valuable insights into digital distraction among International College students, it is limited by its relatively small sample size and its focus on a single educational institution. Future research should include a larger number of participants from different universities and examine additional factors such as digital literacy, learning styles, and classroom observation to develop a broader understanding of digital distraction in higher education.

Overall, the study demonstrates that the challenge is not the presence of digital technology itself but how students choose to use it. When digital devices are integrated responsibly into classroom learning, they can enhance participation, support academic success, and contribute to a more engaging educational experience.

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